India's UN ambassador, Gopalaswamy Ayyangar, articulated Nehru's charge that Pakistan had launched an illegal invasion of Kashmir, insisting that India would agree to a plebiscite only after Pakistan had completely vacated its aggression, withdrawing all its troops and tribal invaders from the state. Pakistan replied it would withdraw its protection of Muslims in the portion of Kashmir it controlled only after India withdrew its entire army from Srinagar and the rest of the Vale of Kashmir. Spokesmen for both countries repeated those positions every time the council met to consider the subject. By the end of January 1948, the Security Council decided to appoint a UN Commission on India and Pakistan (UNCIP), which was to visit South Asia as early as possible to investigate the facts and difficulties on the ground.

On 21 April 1948, the Security Council resolved to send its commission to New Delhi and Karachi to help restore peace and order to Kashmir by preparing the ground there for a plebiscite. The council also called for a cease-fire in Kashmir, to begin on 1 January 1949. A plebiscite administrator was to be nominated by the UN secretary-general, formally appointed by the government of Jammu and Kashmir to ensure the freedom and impartiality of the election.

U.S. Admiral Chester W. Nimitz was the first plebiscite administrator to be nominated, but India judged him unacceptable. A UN cease-fire line in Kashmir, to be monitored by UN observers, was demarcated in July 1949. At year's end, Canada's Security Council president, General A. G. L. McNaughton, attempted to mediate an agreement himself, but failed. "No plebiscite is possible in Kashmir before the refugees are rehabilitated," Nehru insisted. "The price of freedom and progress is blood, sweat and tears." In Srinagar, Nehru told his growing army, "The Kashmir operation is a fight for the freedom of India."

On 14 March 1950, the Security Council passed a resolution calling upon India and Pakistan to prepare themselves for a Kashmir plebiscite within five months. Australia's Sir Owen Dixon was appointed plebiscite mediator; he stayed a month in Kashmir, then shuttled between New Delhi and Karachi until 22 August 1950, when he gave up trying to get the two sides to agree to any formula. Sir Owen's impartiality as a jurist-mediator convinced him that the best solution to the Kashmir conflict would be to partition the state between its Muslim-majority Vale of Kashmir, most of whose inhabitants seemed to favor Pakistan, and its Hindu-Buddhist majorities in Jammu and Ladakh, who apparently favored India. Nehru rejected the idea of partition, however, and refused